



CRYING SHAME CCTV capture of Soumyashree Bisi's self-immolation, Balasore, Jul. 12; inset, video grab of two Dalit men purportedly being forced to eat grass in Ganjam district

▶ ODISHA

LAW AND DISORDER

A college girl's self-immolation, tribal kangaroo courts' bizarre punitive decrees, atrocities against Dalits, a spree of rape: Odisha stares at a law and order nadir

with a social climate of fear, humiliation and impunity. State BJP spokesperson Anil Biswal offers a combative counter: "During BJD rule, there were at least 100 cases that directly involved their leaders, unlike now." But in sheer quantity and quality of crime, so to speak, the present crisis may well be able to hold its own.

STATE OF FEAR

Consider a tribal couple being beaten up, tied to a bamboo yoke like bullocks and forced to plough farmland—for falling in love and marrying secretly. This was not ancient or medieval India. It happened on July 9, and an Indian astronaut was in space while these atavistic scenes unfolded in Kanjamjodi village of Rayagada district. A village 'public', including minors, watched the humiliation. So did a wider shocked public, on a viral video.

It was an exemplary punishment, laid down by a kangaroo court, because the couple were related—the man and his father's cousin, both around 32, had violated old taboos by daring to be together. They were later marched to a shrine, subjected to "purification rituals", then banished from the village. Only public outrage and social media fury got police to the village. A case is now duly under way.

In Ganjam's Dharakot, two Dalit men, falsely accused of cattle smuggling, were forced to crawl with blades of grass between their teeth and drink sewer water. Again, the dehumanisation was filmed, and the video circulated and celebrated online. Nine arrests did come after an outcry, but the confidence with which the crime was carried out—allegedly by groups linked to Hindutva—reflected a dangerous boldness.

Between mid-June and early July alone, Odisha also recorded seven horrifying cases of rape: a woman gangraped on Gopalpur sea beach by 10 men; a 17-year-old girl raped by a clinic owner in Ganjam; an 11-year-old Class VII student tied up and raped in a school toilet by a distant relative, also in Ganjam; a 31-year-old woman gangraped in Mayurbhanj; in Keonjhar, a teenage girl found hanging from a tree with injury marks, her family alleging rape and murder. Some protocol arrests, but beyond that, a deafening—and damning—silence.

Takeaways

- **Between mid-June and early July alone, the state reported seven shocking cases of rape**
- **In Malkangiri's Kotamateru village, at least 30 Christians were injured in an attack**
- **A senior Bhubaneswar Municipal Corporation official was beaten up by goons in his office allegedly linked to the BJP**

COMPLICITY BY INACTION

Religious minorities have had the horrific memories of Kandhamal rekindled. On June 21, nearly 400 people armed with axes and sticks stormed a Christian prayer service for the agricultural season in Malkangiri's Kotamateru village, leaving at least 30 Christians injured—seven of them seriously. Community leaders accused the Bajrang Dal of orchestrating the attack, but the police called it a "dispute between brothers". No arrests. Days later, another mob in the same district brutally beat Christian families during a meal. Again, no substantial police response—reinforcing the perception that the state either cannot or will not act.

Biswal doesn't deny any of these incidents, but says, "In all cases, we have taken prompt action. In the Balasore incident, the University Grants Commission has initiated an inquiry, and the state government has set up a high-level inquiry committee." For now, though, the ledger is brimming over with too many symptoms of a systemic breakdown. ■